

AI for SMEs - Handbook

A living handbook that helps regional manufacturing SMEs put AI to work — written by HAN students, one practical question at a time.

This is the handbook's template. The structure on this page is the shell every cohort fills. The content comes from the teams: researched in the AIBS module, and produced through the research platform the same teams build in AEL. What the handbook is for, who reads it, how it is used and what quality it must reach is specified in each team's product requirements document. That document, not this page, is where the handbook's requirements live.

Placeholders are marked *like this*. A section stays on the page until a cohort fills it; nothing here is published to an SME reader before it has been reviewed (see [About this handbook](#)).

Start here

This handbook is written for owners and managers of small and medium-sized home-care organisations who are new to AI and do not need to be AI experts. It helps understand how AI-supported planning or notifications could help and what must be checked before choosing a tool.

The handbook does not replace professional judgement and does not guarantee that a specific AI tool will work. It also does not prove that Thuiszorg Totaal has the same problem as a larger provider. The original observation came from STMG and is treated only as a hypothesis to test at Thuiszorg Totaal.

The questions this handbook answers

The handbook is organised by **themes**, and every theme is posed as a question an owner would actually ask — not as a topic. The themes are the stable structure; the chapters beneath them compound from cohort to cohort. One theme, one team, one chapter.

#	Theme	The SME-facing question
1	<i>Geopolitics and vendor models</i>	<i>Who owns this thing and what happens to our organisation if that changes?</i>
2	<i>(AI-supported planning and client notifications)</i>	<i>(Is AI safe to use in our organisation and what would adoption require?)</i>
...	<i>one row per theme in the cohort's research spine</i>	

Chapter template

Every chapter has the same anatomy, so an owner who has read one knows how to read the next. A chapter is **SME-translation guidance for one theme, grounded in one illustrative use case**. Copy this block once per theme.

Theme 1 — *Who owns this thing and what happens to our organisation if that changes?*

This chapter helps a Dutch home-care SME understand why it matters who owns and operates the AI tool, where the data goes, and what happens if the vendor or its technology changes.

Team 3 · cohort · version · SME: Thuiszorg Totaal, with consent — or a persona/archetype, and the chapter says which · sources last appraised date

The question, for this kind of SME. *If Thuiszorg Totaal uses an AI-supported scheduling or notification tool, does it matter whether the tool comes from a US hyperscaler, a European vendor or a Dutch care-sector supplier, and what happens if that vendor changes?*

The translation. *What matters the most for Thuiszorg Totaal when choosing an AI tool for scheduling/notifications is the full vendor chain; who provides the software, where the data is stored, which cloud or AI providers are involved, and what happens if one of these companies changes. This is especially important in home care because the system may process sensitive personal or health data. Under GDPR (general data protection regulation), Thuiszorg Totaal remains responsible for this data even when an external AI provider processes it. (AP Publiceert Praktijkids ‘Gezondheidsgegevens in de Cloud’, z.d.)*

A US vendor is not automatically unsafe, and a Dutch or European vendor is not automatically safe. A Dutch supplier may still use an American cloud or AI provider behind its service. For data transfers outside the European Economic Area (EEA), Thuiszorg Totaal must check if a valid GDPR transfer mechanism applies. (EU-US Data Transfers, 2020)

What happens if the vendor changes?

A vendor may be bought by another company, change its cloud or AI provider, add new sub-processors, or move data processing to another country. This can change who has access to Thuiszorg Totaal's data and which rules apply. This does not have to mean the service must stop. Thuiszorg Totaal should be informed about important changes and check whether the new situation still meets GDPR requirements. If the change is not acceptable, the company should be able to object, switch providers, and export or delete its data.

Illustrative use case (CRISP-DM). Example: Thuiszorg Totaal wants to test an AI-supported tool that helps planners create schedules and notify clients about expected care visits.

➤ **Business understanding:** The goal is to reduce manual planning and communication work while keeping the planner in control.

➤ **Data understanding:** First, Thuiszorg Totaal identifies what data the tool would need, such as employee availability, client addresses and appointment times. If health information is involved, this requires extra protection under the GDPR.

➤ **Data preparation:** Only the data that is actually needed should be shared. Thuiszorg Totaal also checks where the data will be stored and which cloud, AI and other providers will have access to it.

➤ **Modelling:** The AI can use the available planning data to suggest schedules or help organise changes. A human planner reviews and approves important decisions.

➤ **Evaluation:** During a small pilot, Thuiszorg Totaal checks whether the tool actually saves time, produces useful results and handles data as agreed. Problems and incorrect suggestions are recorded.

➤ **Deployment:** If the pilot works, the tool can be introduced gradually. Before wider use, Thuiszorg Totaal should have clear agreements about data access, vendor changes, data export and deletion, so it can remain in control or switch providers if necessary.

Recommended tooling. Thuiszorg Totaal should start with the simplest option before buying/integrating a complex AI system.

Option	What it could do	Effort
No-code/low-code platform	Build the first prototype and connect scheduling information without developing a complete system from scratch	Low-medium: requires setup, testing, and basic training
AI scheduling component	Use planning data such as employee availability, locations and time constraints to suggest schedules	Medium-high: requires suitable data, testing and human review
Notification integration	Automatically send approved schedule updates to clients or employees through SMS, email or an app	Medium-high: requires connection to the scheduling system and testing or building an app

Responsible AI & trust. Thuiszorg Totaal remains responsible for its personal and health data when an external provider processes it. The company should therefore know what data is shared, who can access it, where it is processed and how it can be deleted or returned. This follows the guidance of the Dutch Autoriteit Persoonsgegevens for organisations using cloud services for health data. AI output should also not be trusted automatically. During a pilot, planners should check suggested schedules, record mistakes and confirm important changes themselves. The AI should support the planner, not replace human control. For employees, this means being informed about how the tool is used and having a clear way to correct incorrect schedules or decisions. Only the data needed for the task should be shared with the system.

First five steps for an owner:

- **Map the problem:** Identify which scheduling or notification task actually needs improvement.
- **Map the data:** Write down what client and employee data the tool would need.
- **Check the vendor:** Ask who owns the tool, where the data is processed and which cloud, AI and sub-processors are involved.
- **Run a small pilot:** Test the tool with limited data and let planners check its output.
- **Plan the exit:** Before committing, make sure Thuiszorg Totaal can export and delete its data and switch providers if the vendor or conditions change.

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Tooling index

The accessible, mostly no-code tools referenced across the chapters, in one place: what each is for, what it costs in money and effort, and which chapter shows it in use.

Regional ecosystem & support

Where an owner in the region can go next: innovation centres, hubs, training, funding and networks. Organisations are named only with their agreement, and people are not named.

About this handbook

Who writes it. Students of HAN University of Applied Sciences, in teams, as the integrated task of the AIBS module (the research) and the AEL module (the platform it is researched and written with). Each cohort adds new chapters and refreshes existing ones, so the handbook compounds over time.

The quality bar. Every chapter is measured against the same four criteria before it is published: **clarity** for a non-technical reader, **accuracy** against appraised sources, **responsible-AI coverage**, and **usefulness to an SME owner**. Nothing reaches an SME reader unreviewed — chapters are curated by the course team before publication.

Educational, not consultancy. This handbook offers inspiration and starting points, not commercial advice or guarantees. Every chapter carries this disclaimer. Decisions about a firm remain the firm's own.

Confidentiality. Real SME cases are anonymised or published only with consent. Sensitive or identifying data never enters the public handbook.